

Thejo Akkoor

Honors 493

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Part 1: Interview Transcript

Veera: I'm [ahem] English language is not my mother tongue though but um I started learning English from a very very young age uhh say around um during my kindergarten age and I would say I'm pretty eloquent at speaking, reading, writing English.

Thejo: What does grammar mean to you?

Veera: [ahem] Grammar is the right way to um exhibit and uh articulate things (...)

Thejo: Okay, and would you say that it's something that you learned in school or something that—

Veera: Yeah yeah yeah um I did, I did study in a convent, English convent, so I learned the grammatical uh nuances when I studied that yeah

Thejo: Okay so it was like a Christian school?

Veera: yes, it was a Christian missionary uh convent and umm I had gone through almost [ahem] in my schooling of twelve years at least six years was in uh, you know, in a English convent. So grammar is very essential uh in order to exhibit or express ourselves in the right manner

Thejo: Ok um and would you uh say that you learned, you learned British English?

Veera: Uh yes, uh because we were in India when I grew up uh yes uh British English was the way that [ahem] we used to um talk and at least uh learn.

Thejo: Yeah, and and how did that change when you came to America?

Veera: uhh there are certain nuances the uh the slang and the way that things need to be expressed changed when I came to America. Uh for example uh “route” became “route”, “center” became “centre”, um spelling was different umm “analyze” was you know a uh I used uh z, uh we used to say “zed” and uh it became “z” and uh “organisation” became “organization” right uh so uh it was an “s” there but here it's a z, right, so those are kind of the small small things that change. But mostly I would say the manners and the way that British manners um mannerisms were was a bit umm you know uh hard uh hard hard it'll be hard I would say like you know the way you express used to be more uh you know uh uh uh um [ahem] not uh I would

say rigid right? That was a rigid, rigid was the word right, we used to be more rigid in uh talking whereas here it's more free, American english is more free, where you can express yourself uh (...) lightly and you'll be understood, uh whereas in British English, you've got to be very very uh formal and the way that you talk and you address so those are the kind of things which might uh which uh at least I found different s–

Part 2: Reflection

Is My English *Wrong*? (with my Indian father)

- 1) *Center* not *centre*. *Organization* not *organisation*. 'Z' not 'zed'. These are just a few instances of the English language changing from British to American dialects. Having been under British colonization (or *colonisation*) for almost 90 years, most Indians became – at least at the base level – well-versed in British English. My dad grew up in Chennai, which was also known as the former British colony Madras, India. Because of its metropolitan origins, most children raised in Chennai attend Christian English Medium schooling from a young age, which instilled in them a foundation for a lifetime of speaking the language. However, for most of those Indians that journey across the Atlantic to the United States, there is a clear shift in pronunciation, spelling, and articulation of words. This is not only true between the two countries, but also within the United States.

My father's relationship with the English language was shaped by his education and environment. He proclaimed that in his opinion, English grammar is “the right way to exhibit and articulate things”, explaining that it is essential to exhibit or express oneself in the correct manner. He emphasized the formality of British English that he grew up learning by describing the different customs to which he had to adjust when he moved to America 30 years ago. For example, it was commonplace in India to address others with *sir* and *ma'am* as opposed to simply using first names. He defined himself as a traditionalist in terms of language use through expressing an anti-slang stance. He described words like *low-key* and *kinda* as unnecessary shortenings of words that lack professionalism in official settings.

He strongly cautioned against taboo language and slang terms in professional settings, which included the use of discourse markers and filler words (i.e. *like*, *um*), explaining that they were repetitive and diverted from the main point of a conversation or talk. However, what he did not pay attention to was his own unintentional use of filler words during the interview, for example, “I would say like you know the way you express used to be more uh you know uh uh uh um [ahem] not uh I would say rigid right?”. Valerie Fridland, in her novel *Like, Literally, Dude* described the use of *uh* and *um* as hesitation signals to mark that a speaker was thinking about what to say next (Fridland 77).

However, my dad seemed to use them as filler words that did not precede any pause to signal thinking. As a result, these fillers were serving more of a negative than positive purpose, depicting exactly what he found to be *bad* language. It seems as though his use of *uh* is akin to this generation's overuse of the filler *like* – something that he ironically seemed to *dis-like*.

In terms of taboo language, he argued that swear words are currently being overused in professional settings, which sets a bad precedent for future generations. Timothy Jay in his article, *The Utility and Ubiquity of Taboo Words*, seemed to echo the belief that people often report swearing to promote social harmony or cohesion (Jay 154). My dad viewed this use of taboo language as unacceptable, and claimed instead that conducting oneself in a professional manner in all settings – especially that of official spaces – is vital to maintaining decorum.

While he mentioned all of these points as the interview progressed, when explicitly asked what he would define as 'good' and 'bad' English, he said, "there's nothing like good English and bad English unless you are going to talk in a forum. When you talk to me one on one, if you are able to articulate things enough to be comprehensible, then that is enough". He emphasized that there should not be a stigma towards people who cannot speak or understand English well.

- 2) Dictionary definitions are found in essays, presentations, and everyday life as a way of appearing authoritative and informed. Although my dad felt there was no 'right' or 'wrong' in English, he described dictionaries as "one of the best things around" in terms of authority and information of English words. Further, he stated that every word –good or bad – should be included in dictionaries. When asked about whether dictionaries are restricting in terms of access and social class, he argued that there should be a board that decides what words are included, but ultimately felt that dictionaries are beneficial as opposed to restricting. Specifically, he expressed that old school *Merriam-Webster* and *Oxford English* dictionaries are the best ways to learn English. He remarked that it was disappointing that this is no longer happening. Further, my dad explained that he used to alphabetically read through and memorize words and their meanings in the Webster dictionary during his summer vacation. It can be therefore plausible that his respect for the dictionary as a supreme authority was a direct result of his experiences with it as a child.

But are dictionaries really *all that*? According to Bob Garfield from the Lexicon Valley podcast's *The Story of Ain't*, 'Webster's Second Dictionary' set itself up as the "authority" of English that was not to be questioned by anyone (Vuolo, 2012). Further, according to Allison Flood from *The Guardian* in her article about the definition of the

word *rabid* in the Oxford English Dictionary, dictionaries reflect restricting views seen in the example sentence “Perhaps the entire staff of the school were rabid feminists but if so we did not know, and we certainly weren’t.” Canadian anthropologist Michael Oman-Reagan echoed the views of many in arguing that this held a sexist stance on feminism (Flood, 2016).

Essentially, dictionary definitions can become very contextualized and reflect the experiences of a certain group of people who are known as prescriptivists, or people that want to ‘preserve’ old grammar. When new words, or unorthodox ideas are introduced, people tend to express their dislike for them. Case in point, my dad proclaiming himself a ‘traditionalist’ who does not identify with slang potentially due to his unfamiliarity with the origin of those words.

- 3) Although even nonnative speakers of English like my father point to the authority of the dictionary and the use of ‘correct’ grammar, it is difficult to completely standardize the English language even just within the United States. However, in the written word, English is extremely standardized. The various ways of addressing a group of people (i.e. y’all, you guys, youse, yinz) are condensed into a perceived formal version, *you all*.

Further, while people assume there are ‘accentless’ speakers (i.e. people in the Midwest, newscasters, adopters of the *Transatlantic* way of speaking), accents are inevitable in spoken language. In the article, *Is There a Place in America Where People Speak With Neutral Accents?*, author Dan Nosowitz proposes an experiment to listen to newscasters from different regions in the US. This reveals a newscaster from Georgia who pronounces ‘ten’ as ‘tin’, and a newscaster from Southern California pronouncing ‘kit’ as ‘ket’ (Nosowitz, 2022). Although these are minor details, they are still audible differences that can be traced back to a specific region (Nosowitz, 2022). This is all in the *articulatory precision* of their language, or the way they enunciate certain words. Furthermore, in the written word, there is a standardized form of words and sounds, hiding any sort of articulation or pronunciation. With this absence in pronunciation comes a certain loss in personality and identity, as Laura Relya puts forth in *With Drawl*, wherein she describes the loss of her southern accent as a result of the stigma against southerners after moving to Chicago. Although she standardized her formerly strong southern accent, she felt as though a part of her identity was lost thereafter (Relyea, 2021). The written word quite literally characterizes this loss in identity and personality by which people conform to the stigma against regional or ‘non-traditional’ dialects of English.

Clearly, the work of those aiming to standardize English has succeeded in the written word. The interview with my dad makes it clear that perfection in English stems from the

written form that lacks filler words and discourse markers. However, the overarching question remains about whether written English should remain standardized or mimic spoken English in its natural use. This is something we must reckon with until the end of time because spoken English is only evolving with each passing minute, and traditionalists like my dad must evolve alongside it.

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